

GYMS, SALONS AND FASHION

Join the Brat Wagon

Today's kids are no longer happy being cute, they want a groomed and fitter look. And apparel brands, salons and gyms are more than happy to woo these little customers.

On a hot Saturday afternoon, Watermelon, a specialised salon for young adults, is a riot. In place of fashion magazines, the spacious salon is littered with funky soft toys and PlayStation 2 consoles. Ruff, a premium clothing brand for children, started Watermelon salon to build brand equity with their little customers by making them spend more time at the clothes store. But the sight of a dozen and a half toddlers going berserk in this trendy salon is a clear testimony of the fact that the experiment is now proving to be a compelling business option.

If India is a consumerist society today, where the adults are living it up, the juniors are not far behind. From pester power to direct consumption, the teens and the pre-teen segment is driving consumption and forcing marketers to create new categories, product lines and service offerings. So from salons, gyms to exclusive clothes and jewellery lines are available for the very demanding market segment. Explaining the market for children, Anand Patel, brand manager of Ruff, which has started Watermelon salons in five cities, says: "We wanted to get into high fashion grooming market for children. The salon started out as a value added service to drive footfalls into the stores, but today it seems like a compelling business opportunity even outside the stores." While Watermelon started out as a hook for the mainline apparel stores, From Tears to Cheers, another salon for kids in south Mumbai was born after Tripti Arya, the store's proprietor, saw such salons in the USA. From popular hair cuts for girls and boys, the salon offers manicures and pedi-



GETTING TRIM: (above) Moin getting his hair styled at Watermelon Salon in Mumbai, (right, far right) children work out at Tree House, an exclusive gym for Kids

cures for kids. "We just clean the feet and hands and clip the nails," says Arya. The treatments are very different from the ones done on adults.

The trend has caught the fancy of other metros as well. The ambience at A Cut Above Children in Chennai is aesthetically designed with its customers in mind. Painted prettily in an array of bright colours, the studio has a tiny library for children and a host of book and crayons too. Children in the age group of six to 14 years soak in this space while waiting for their turn.

The market for kids is evidently on a boil, if the numbers are to be believed. According to Technopak, the overall

